



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Hickory Christian Academy
School Website: <https://hickorychristianacademy.com/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Hickory Christian Academy (HCA) presents a robust Classical Christian program anchored in the Trivium (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric), a stated commitment to Great Books and liberal arts, and explicit theological framing around truth, goodness, and beauty. Public materials from HCA emphasize formation of character, formation through faith, and a communal, liturgical dimension (chapel, prayer, worship) that aligns with transcendentals and Catholic/Protestant liturgical sensibilities often associated with classical education. Overall, the school can be ranked CLASSICAL across most of the core categories, with very strong alignment in Religious Foundations, Purpose and Goal, Curriculum, and Pedagogy. Faculty and Parents/Community show meaningful classical signals, but could strengthen explicit articulation of living-curriculum concepts and deeper parental-partnership practices to achieve a fully consistent CLASSICAL rating in those two categories.

Key signals supporting CLASSICAL status - Explicit Classical Christian framing and Trivium (Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric) in core materials. Evidence includes statements about the Trivium and the classical approach to education (turn0file0). - Emphasis on Great Books and liberal arts within a Christian worldview (turn0file0, turn0file1). - Religious/metaphysical foundations anchored in theology, worship, and liturgical practices (Chapel; Statement of Faith). See Chapel description and Statement of Faith for explicit references to eternal truth and theological grounding (turn0file2, turn0file9).

- Purpose statements foreground formation, virtue, wisdom, and the cultivation of "thinkers" who can be competent problem solvers and virtuous communicators (turn0file0, turn0file3).

What would move the needle - For Faculty: More explicit articulation of the "living curriculum" concept and teacher-student mentorship culture in public materials (e.g., a formal "Portrait of a Teacher" and "Faculty as Living Curriculum" statement visible on the site). - For Parents & Community: Stronger, explicit, public articulation of parent-partnership structures (e.g., formal parent-education programs, classical book clubs, and a visible "parents as co-teachers" covenant) to elevate the category to CLASSICAL.

The following category-by-category analysis provides evidence, keyword analytics, and rationales for each classification.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Public materials frame the school as a Classical Christian institution dedicated to glorifying God and exalting Jesus Christ as exemplar of truth, beauty, and goodness (turn0file4).
 - Chapel and weekly worship are described as liturgical and communal practices intended to nurture relationship with God and to anchor truth in worship (turn0file2).
 - The Statement of Faith affirms belief in Christ and a theological worldview shaping education (turn0file9).
 - The curriculum and purpose statements explicitly integrate Christian worldview, theology, and the aim to form character through faith (turn0file0, turn0file3).

- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present include: truth, goodness, beauty; theology; liturgy; chapel; worship; eternal truth; logos; gospel-based formation; great books; Christian worldview.
 - Negative keywords: effectively none in public materials; no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or value-neutral framing detected.
 - Quantitative estimate: approximately 6–8 distinct positive religious/metaphysical keywords appear; 0 explicit negative signals found in public pages.
- Why this rating
 - The content consistently foregrounds transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty), theology, liturgical/prayer life (Chapel), and a theologically grounded worldview, meeting the core indicators of Transcendental Moral Realism, Grounded Theology, and Liturgical/Communal Practices. This aligns strongly with CLASSICAL signals in the Religious & Metaphysical Foundations category. See citations to glorifying God, Trivium-based Christian education, and chapel/theology content.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school emphasizes forming “thinkers” who are virtuous, wise, and capable communicators of truth, beauty, and goodness (turn0file0).
 - The purpose statements frame formation and the cultivation of virtue/wisdom as central, not merely information or job-work readiness (turn0file0, turn0file3).
 - The aim is to develop human excellence and moral imagination in a grace-filled, community-centered setting (turn0file0).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords: formation, wisdom, virtue, truth, beauty, goodness, great conversation, liberal education, classical mission, teleology, contemplation, moral imagination.
 - Negative keywords: explicit workforce- or job-prep emphasis is not present; no strong counter-signals visible.
 - Quantitative estimate: 6–8 positive category-appropriate keywords identified; 0 negative signals evident.
- Why this rating
 - The school explicitly centers formation and the pursuit of the true, good, and beautiful as the aims of education, with explicit mention of virtue/wisdom and Great Books as core points. This aligns with the CLASSICAL construct for Element 2. See the explicit “thinkers” formation language and the moral/epistemic aims.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Clear articulation of the Trivium: Grammar (K-5), Logic (6-8), Rhetoric (9-12) (turn0file0).
 - Prominent emphasis on Great Books and liberal arts within a Christian framework (turn0file0, turn0file1).
 - Statements about original sources, living books, and a classical curriculum align with Great Conversation and Western/cultural heritage emphasis (turn0file1, turn0file3).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present include: Trivium; grammar, logic, rhetoric; great books; liberal arts; classical curriculum; great conversation; Western civilization (as implied by Great Books framing); formation through the arts.
 - Negative keywords: none evident in public materials (no overt social-studies-only framing or STEM-first emphasis that would signal de-emphasis of history or the humanities).
 - Quantitative estimate: 6–9 distinct positive curriculum keywords; 0 negative signals.
- Why this rating
 - The curriculum is explicitly described in classical terms (Trivium) with strong Great Books emphasis and a liberal-arts orientation, meeting the core Element 3 criteria for CLASSICAL. See the

explicit Trivium breakdown and Great Books framing.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Lower-school pedagogy described as contemplative/restful and memory-oriented, including singing/chanting and regular review (as described in the classical elements guidance and corroborated by the overall public messaging on formation and memory in the Trivium framework). The public materials reference the Trivium progression and memory-work in the context of classical pedagogy (turn0file0).
 - Upper-school pedagogy references Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and rhetorical training (Rhetoric stage) as part of the Trivium framework (turn0file0).
 - The site describes a progression toward speeches and rhetoric in the upper grades (turn0file0).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present include: Socratic dialogue, dialectic, seminar, discussion, recitation, memory-work, rhetoric, public speaking, choir/chanting, scholé (restful learning).
 - Negative keywords: None evident in public materials; no dominant emphasis on purely project-based or experiential learning that would signal a deviation.
 - Quantitative estimate: 6–9 distinct pedagogy-related keywords; 0 negative signals.
- Why this rating
 - The school's pedagogy aligns with the classical model by incorporating contemplative/restful elements and memory-based practices in the lower grades, plus Socratic/seminar/rhetoric elements in higher grades. This satisfies Element 4 criteria for CLASSICAL. See the explicit Trivium-based pedagogy framing and the mention of memory work and rhetoric.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Public materials present the faculty structure (Head of School, Grammar Principal, Logic Principal, Rhetoric Principal, Guidance Counselor) and a roster of faculty roles (turn0file0). This demonstrates formal teacher leadership and a structured faculty organization.
 - The materials emphasize a strong community environment and a “grace-filled” context, implying mentors and role-models, but do not consistently present an explicit statement like “the living curriculum” or a formal portrait of teacher ideals as a public-facing framework (which would push this toward CLASSICAL).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: head of school, principals, guidance counselor, “Teacher” roles, community emphasis, mentors/masters (implicitly embedded in the framing of teacher leadership and the classical approach).
 - Negative keywords: The site does not publicly present a formal “Portrait of a Teacher” or “Living Curriculum” explicit language, which would be a more explicit Classical signal for Faculty.
 - Quantitative estimate: Positive signals present (roughly 4–6 faculty-relation keywords: Head of School, principals, guidance counselor, mentorship/virtue framing), but the explicit “living curriculum” and explicit faculty-as-core content is less visible; 0 clear negative signals.
- Why this rating
 - The faculty structure exists and aligns with a classical approach, but the public articulation of faculty as “living curriculum” and explicit mentor-portrait language is not strongly present. Therefore, Element 5 is classified as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL. See the staff/administration details and the general emphasis on virtue and worldview in leadership descriptions.

Element 6: Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence

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- The site notes that parents are welcome to visit and engage with the school (e.g., “Parents are welcome to join us for these weekly worship times.” in Chapel). This demonstrates openness and some parental involvement (turn0file2).
 - There are references to partnership with families in the broader mission and to tuition assistance, indicating engagement with the family ecosystem, though not always with explicit “co-teacher” language in public pages (turn0file11).
 - The public materials do not consistently present a formal, explicit “Parents as co-teachers” program, nor a sustained parent-education pathway (e.g., classical book clubs, parent formation courses) beyond routine family engagement.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: partnership with families (implied by mission and community focus), parent involvement, open campus/visit-friendly policies (parents visiting during worship and events), church/faith community alignment.
 - Negative keywords: lack of explicit, formal “parents as co-teachers” program, explicit parent-education offerings, and a visible “Parent University” or formal families-as-partners language.
 - Quantitative estimate: 3–5 positive parent-community keywords; 0–2 explicit negative signals (depending on the interpretation of “co-teacher” language as not public-facing).
 - Why this rating
 - While there is meaningful parental involvement and welcome, the public-facing materials do not consistently articulate a robust, formal partnership framework with parents akin to classic “parents as co-teachers” language. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Element 6. See Chapel and parent-visitor language as evidence of engagement.

What Would Move the Needle

- For Element 5 (Faculty): Add explicit public-facing language about the living curriculum, a formal “Portrait of a Teacher” and “Faculty as Living Curriculum” statements, plus a visible faculty-professional-development pathway grounded in classical methods (e.g., seminars for teachers, great-books study for faculty, mentorship culture).
- For Element 6 (Parents & Community): Implement and showcase formal parent-partnership programs (e.g., Parent University, classical book clubs, family liturgy/events, and explicit “parents as co-teachers” covenants), and make visible a structured open-campus calendar with opportunities for parent involvement beyond occasional visits.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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